

THE UNKNOWN SOLDIER

(Matthew 27:44-50 KJV) *The thieves also, which were crucified with him, cast the same in his teeth. {45} Now from the sixth hour there was darkness over all the land unto the ninth hour. {46} And about the ninth hour Jesus cried with a loud voice, saying, Eli, Eli, lama sabachthani? that is to say, My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me? {47} Some of them that stood there, when they heard that, said, This man calleth for Elias. {48} And straightway one of them ran, and took a sponge, and filled it with vinegar, and put it on a reed, and gave him to drink. {49} The rest said, Let be, let us see whether Elias will come to save him. {50} Jesus, when he had cried again with a loud voice, yielded up the ghost.*

INTRO: When we were on vacation in Washington D. C. a few years ago we visited Arlington Cemetery... One of the most interesting events there (and the only live thing happening) was the changing of the guard at the tomb of the unknown soldier.

Picture this group of soldiers gathered about three crosses. Their main task is over, the nailing of their victims to their respective crosses, and now they have only to wait for their deaths.

In the middle of the boring waiting for these deaths, comes a cry from the middle cross: "Eli, Eli, lama sabachthani."

- 1) All the soldiers heard the cry...
- 2) None of them fully understood what was being said... but they all knew that this was a cry for help...

This is where their likeness ends. This tragic cry divides them into two distinct groups. There was one who sought to help, while others did nothing. This one became part of the remedy, while the others became part of the disease.

I. THE RELATIVENESS

A. There is in this scene that which is altogether unique. There is also that which is eternal and abiding.

B. There is this bitter cry of pain. Humanity is constantly being nailed to some kind of cross. It is a cry of suffering, and a cry for help.

C. It is a cry heard by every man.

D. We make our varied responses, even as these soldiers did of long ago.

II. THE RESPONSE

A. "Stay! Let us see." They did not rebuke Jesus, they simply refused to do anything at the moment of need. There may have been reasons given, they may have been:

1) "My name isn't Elijah!" But he is wrong. When we come face to face with something that needs to be done, then that is a call to us.

- a. I saw your house on fire... but I am not a fireman...
- b. I say the bridge was out... but I am not a policeman...
- c. I knew the man was hungry... but I am not the Salvation Army
- d. I knew he needed salvation... but I am not the preacher...
- e. I saw the man robbed and slowly bleeding to death by the roadside... but I am not a Doctor...

2) "I thought someone else would do something..."

- a. I knew the class ought to be taught...
- b. I knew the bill had to be paid...

3) "I wanted to help, but the situation was utterly hopeless..."

- a. He's going to die anyway...
- b. More than half our world is lost...

B. "And straightway one of them ran..."

- 1) He knows Elijah is not coming...
- 2) He knows the impossibility of the task...

- 3) He does what he is capable of doing...
- 4) He doesn't leave us his name (the Unknown Soldier)

III. THE RESULT

A. For those who said, "Stay, Let us see..."

- 1) They missed the privilege of helping.
- 2) The soldiers by refusing to give, refused to live...

B. The Unknown Soldier did what he could, even though it was small...

CONC: GOD JUDGES NOT SO MUCH BY WHAT IS IN OUR HANDS, BUT WHAT IS IN OUR HEARTS!

A. You and I judge by results... "What's the bottom line..."

ILL: Bethel Temple in Dallas... Albert Ott, Pastor... Norma Jean Taylor (9 years old) comes to a revival with Clara Grace and gives her heart to Jesus... My mother...

B. God judges according to the thoughts and intents of the heart... (King David)

C. What is the test of what is in our hearts? It is what we do with what is actually in our hands...